

The changing tastes of a changing city: Boston's best-in-show exhibit a real eye-opener

Campbell, Robert
Boston Globe (1960-); Apr 26, 1981; ProQuest
 pg. A26

ARCHITECTURE

The changing tastes of a changing city

Boston's best-in-show exhibit a real eye-opener



By Robert Campbell

What amounts to a capsule history of Boston architecture in the 20th century is on view at the Boston Architectural Center.

It's an exhibit, in photographs, of all the winners of the Harleston Parker Medal. Since 1923, the Boston Society of Architects has been giving this prize to one Boston building per year for good design.

Lined up on panels at the BAC, the Parker Medalists look wonderful and awful, hilarious and boring. They show as nothing else could the wild fluctuation of tastes in architecture over the past five decades.

Would you believe, for instance, the Motor Mart Garage in Park Square? Yes, that was picked as the best new building for 1927. No doubt the awards jury was pleased that someone had finally found a way to make that new necessity of urban life, the parking garage, look as much as possible like a Roman mausoleum.

The Parker winners slot neatly into their categories of style. There's a big run on red-brick imitation Georgian in the 1930s, for instance, most of it in and around Harvard. Just a bit of Art Deco surfaces in the Hatch Shell of 1941 and the John Hancock Tower (the old one) of 1950. The Hancock building of 1924 is a winner, too, but so far the mirrored tower of the 1970s hasn't made it.

There's a lot of stripped-down eclectic from the 1920s right up into the 1950s, when sleek modern takes over. Burr Hall at Harvard, a sleek-modern entry, won the Parker for 1953. It's a pleasantly ironic index of changing values that Seymour Slive,

the current director of Harvard's Fogg Art Museum, has recently been describing Burr as one of the worst buildings of the 20th century. Though Burr is only 30 years old, Harvard will demolish it this summer to make way for a new addition to the Fogg.

Sleek modern gives way to bulkier, more sculptured modern in 1960s designs like Boston City Hall, the Christian Science Center, the Design Research Store, the Holyoke Center and others. This year's Parker winner also falls into this category.

It's the Dreyfus Laboratory at MIT, designed by the I.M. Pei Partnership, a firm that has now won the Parker Medal three times (tying it with Ben Thompson and the Architects Collaborative, one behind the four medals for Sert, Jackson and Associates). Dreyfus is a characteristic Pei design of smooth, warm-toned concrete, sharply angled, with bold incised openings and flawless minimal detailing. It is most successful in the way it takes its place as part of the ever-growing architectural matrix that is MIT without either showing off or looking dull.

This is the first time the Parker Medalists have ever been gathered in one place. The show runs through April 30.

□

Spring is the season for awards and, besides the Parker Medal, another has been announced.

This is the annual Boston Export Award, also given by the Boston Society of Architects. The Export Awards are given to Boston firms for work they've done anywhere outside the Boston area. The idea is to publicize the fact that Boston is one of the leading centers of architecture and that Boston architects design buildings just about everywhere on earth.

The four Export Awards are: Harborplace in Baltimore, by Benjamin Thompson and Associates, a complex of shops and restaurants that repeats many of the qualities of Thompson's Quincy Market here (a Parker Medalist in 1977).

Pickering Wharf in Salem, by ADD Inc., a group of shops and dwellings on the waterfront.

Aga Khan Medical College Nurses' School in Pakistan, by Payette Associates, Inc.

Syracuse University Hall of Language, by Architectural Resources Cambridge, a renovation

Robert Campbell is the *Globe's* architecture critic. His commentary appears regularly in *Focus*.

PHOTO BY NATHANIEL LIEBERMAN



Far left: The old John Hancock building, the 1924 winner of the Harleston Parker Medal.

Left: MIT's Dreyfus Lab., designed by the I.M. Pei Partnership, this year's Parker winner.

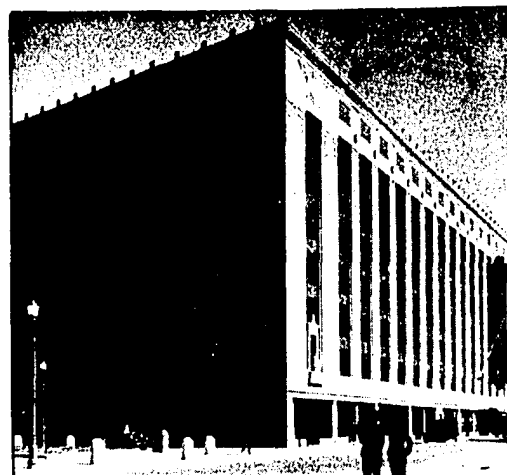


PHOTO BY STEVE ROSENTHAL

Far left: The Motor Mart Garage in Park Square, picked as the best new building of 1927.

Left: Syracuse University's Hall of Languages, a renovation by Architectural Resources Cambridge, one of this year's Export Award winners.



PHOTO BY STEVE ROSENTHAL

Far left: Burr Hall at Harvard, the 1953 Parker Medalist.

Left: Salem's Pickering Wharf by ADD Inc., another of this year's Export Award winners.